Name: _____
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AOU
الجامعة العربية المفتوحة
Arab Open University
Faculty of Language Studies

Arab Open University

FACULTY OF LANGUAGE STUDIES

EL122
Writing Research
MAIN- All Branches
FINAL Exam

2025/2026 Fall
Date: 14 Jan. 2026
1:00 – 3:00

Number of Exam Pages: 9 (including this cover sheet)	**Time Allowed: 2 hours**

This exam consists three parts. Please check the following table for grade computation

Exam Part	Earned Points	Grader's Signature
Part A	/15	
Part B	/20	
Part C	/15	
Total	/50	

Instructions

ke sure you complete all the necessary information such as your name, your registratio
er, and your section number on this cover sheet

s exam has 3 parts

wers must be written neatly and legibly

nd some time at the end to revise your spelling and grammar

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PART A: [15 points]
Read the following passage and respond to the prompts that follow it:

PART A: [15 points]

Read the following passage and respond to the prompts that follow it:

studies show a significant change in how young adults relate to one another. A 2023 report by the Global Social Behavior Institute found that over 70% of Gen Z feels more comfortable communicating online than in person, signaling a cultural shift toward highly individualized digital interaction. As social media platforms continue to dominate daily life, many young people rely on curated online identities to express themselves, shaping the way they build relationships, interpret emotions, and understand others. The rise of social-media-driven individualism among Gen Z has contributed to a decline in empathy, which can be seen in their difficulty interpreting emotional cues, their avoidance of meaningful conflict resolution, and their reduced investment in deep interpersonal relationships.

One sign of this empathy decline appears in Gen Z's struggle to read emotional nuance during face-to-face interactions. Because much of their communication happens through screens, where tone and expression are limited or entirely absent, many young adults find real-life emotions harder to understand. This issue becomes particularly clear in the case of Omar, a first-year university student who relied almost exclusively on messaging apps during high school. When he entered university, he often misinterpreted classmates' expressions or took jokes literally because he lacked experience reading body language. He later admitted that interacting mostly online had left him uncertain about how to navigate emotional situations in person.

Another indication of weakening empathy is the way Gen Z handles interpersonal conflict. Instead of addressing disagreements directly, many young adults turn to digital distancing tools—muting, blocking, or avoiding communication altogether. Counselors on university campuses frequently report that students prefer withdrawing or venting on social media instead of engaging in honest, difficult conversations. This tendency prevents them from developing patience, perspective-taking, and the ability to understand others' emotions in moments of tension.

A final expression of declining empathy is Gen Z's preference for brief, low-commitment social interactions. The design of social platforms encourages quick exchanges, curated self-presentation, and minimal vulnerability. As a result, many young adults choose online environments that offer control and convenience rather than the effort required to build emotionally rich relationships. Researchers note that although Gen Z is more digitally connected

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than any previous generation, many still describe feeling isolated and unsupported in their offline lives.

"Individualism in the Digital Age: Empathy Decline Among Gen Z," Hana Masoud

1. What hook technique is used in the passage? [1 point]

_____

2. What verb tense is primarily used throughout passage, and what is its purpose? [1 point]

_____

3. When does the writer in this passage switch the verb tense, and why is the switch made? [2 points]

_____

4. Identify the thesis statement in the passage. [1 point]

_____

5. Paraphrase the following sentence, bearing in mind the characteristics of a good paraphrase.

"Although technology has the potential to enhance learning, its benefits depend on students developing healthier and more disciplined approaches to digital use."

."

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[3 point]

5. List three points from the passage in support of the thesis. [3 points]

- _____
- _____
- _____

6. Write a response to the passage using the "Personal Experience" method. [4 points]

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_____

_____

_____

Part B: [20 points]

1. **For <u>each</u> thesis statement, write <u>TWO</u> topic sentences (bearing in mind the qualities of a good topic sentence) to introduce each of the main sections of a hypothetical paper. Next, use the appropriate piece of evidence among those <u>listed below</u> to support the topic sentences you constructed (bearing in mind the proper integration process). [10 points for each thesis]**

Thesis Statement (A): The overuse of digital devices among university students negatively affects their <u>academic performance</u>, <u>mental well-being</u>, and <u>face-to-face communication skills</u>.

Topic Sentence 1: [2 point]

_____

_____

_____

Explanation of the topic sentence: [2 point]

_____

_____

_____

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The "adequate" supporting evidence. [1 point]

_____

_____

_____

Topic Sentence 2: [2 points]

_____

_____

_____

Explanation of the topic sentence: [2 points]

_____

_____

_____

The "adequate" supporting evidence. [1points]

_____

_____

_____

Pieces of evidence for Thesis statement (A)

- A 2022 study conducted at Kuwait National University found that students who spent more than six hours per day on their smartphones had significantly lower GPAs than those who limited their daily use to three hours or less.

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- In a 2020 article published in the Journal of Student Well-Being, researchers reported that high levels of daily screen time were strongly associated with increased anxiety, sleep disruption, and feelings of burnout among university students.

- A campus observation report by Al-Harthy (2021) notes that many students sit together in groups but focus mainly on their phones, leading to fewer face-to-face conversations and weaker interpersonal communication skills.

Thesis Statement (B): Excessive reliance on digital devices among university students weakens their time-management skills, reduces their ability to engage deeply with course material, and limits their participation in campus life.

Topic Sentence 1: [2 point]

_____

_____

_____

Explanation of the topic sentence: [2 point]

_____

_____

_____

The "adequate" supporting evidence. [1 point]

_____

_____

_____

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Topic Sentence 2: [2 points]

_____

_____

_____

Explanation of the topic sentence: [2 points]

_____

_____

_____

The "adequate" supporting evidence. [1points]

_____

_____

_____

Pieces of evidence for Thesis statement (B)

- A 2021 survey from Gulf University reported that students who checked their phones more than twenty times per hour struggled significantly with planning tasks, often missing deadlines due to constant digital interruptions.
- In a study published in the International Review of Education (2022), researchers found that students who toggled between academic work and social media during study sessions retained 40% less information than peers who studied without device switching.
- A campus engagement report from Al-Qadri (2020) noted that clubs and student organizations observed declining attendance, with many students preferring to stay on their devices during free time rather than joining extracurricular activities.

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Part C: **[15 points]**

a. **Read the following passage. Identify the seven connecting words and phrases and explain the function of each. [2 points each]**

Digital device use is becoming increasingly common among university students; however, it is important to examine how it affects their academic habits. Many students, such as first-year undergraduates, rely heavily on their phones throughout the day. For example, some students check social media during lectures, losing focus on important explanations. Also, constant notifications interrupt study sessions and make it harder to finish assignments on time. In other words, frequent screen use disrupts students' ability to concentrate deeply on their coursework. When students use their devices late into the night, their sleep schedules become irregular, thus affecting their energy levels and performance the next day.

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

6. _____

7. _____

b. **To what does the underlined pronoun "their" refer in the passage? [1 point]**

_____

End of Exam

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